CoralNPU on AWS F2: Gemma 3 1B and FunctionGemma 270M

Inference status report

Ergodex – coralnpu_bonsai, branch `model-kernels-firmware`

2026-10-14

1 Summary

Both models run end to end on Alex's F2 image (`agfi-075a98d106eb1b6bf`, small shell `0x10212415`) using hand-written CoralNPU kernels under `models/`. On the FPGA, FunctionGemma 270M generates *token-identical* output to the MLX bf16 reference for the chat prompt used throughout this report, and Gemma 3 1B generates exactly the tokens of the NumPy reference that reproduces the device's Q4_0/int8 arithmetic. Throughput on the image is bound by external memory: the core streams about 0.7 bytes per cycle at 25 MHz for every load form. Two kernel generations are reported: the per-operator kernels (one launch per operator), and a *fused* single-token decode kernel written in assembly (one launch per generated token, activations and scales kept in DTCM, f16 scales, logits never written out). The fused kernel cuts FunctionGemma decode from 27.7 to 11.6 s per token with identical output; Gemma 3 1B decode from 72.6 to 41.4 s per token, again with identical tokens. Table 2 lists the measured time to first token (TTFT) and tokens per second; the report is regenerated from the result files (`report/collect.py`).

2 Setup

FPGA EC2 `f2.6xlarge` `fpga-dev-f2` (`i-00a83cab3c81ac10f`), slot 0, Alex's AFI. Core: `CoralF2Axi` at 25 MHz, 8 KiB ITCM, 32 KiB DTCM, RVV (VLEN 128, Zve32f) and the Zvt matrix engine with int8 and f32 modes only (no bf16 anywhere). DDR (1 GiB window at `0x80000000`) holds weights, HBM (`0xC0000000`) holds activations, the KV cache and RoPE tables.

Software One ELF per operator (`models/kernels`), built on the instance with clang-18 and lld (`models/firmware/build.sh`); the host runtime (`models/host/runtime.py`) sequences the kernels over PCIe through the AWS FPGA SDK.

Weights Gemma 3 1B: Q4_0 from `gaunernst/gemma-3-1b-it-int4-gguf`, kept exactly (int4 codes in groups of 32 with f16 scales). FunctionGemma 270M: bf16 safetensors from the public MLX mirror `mlx-community/functiongemma-270m-it-bf16`, quantized to the same Q4_0 blocks. Activations are int8 per 32-wide group; residual stream, norms, attention and the KV cache are f32.

MLX reference `mlx-lm` on this Mac (Apple M2 Max, 32 GiB), greedy decoding, same chat template and tokenizer. `mlx-community/functiongemma-270m-it-bf16` and `mlx-community/gemma-3-1b-it-qat-4bit`.

Other paths The IREE / coralnpu-compiler path (branch `fpga-workflow`: F2 PCIe backend, int4 Gemma export, MPACT golden) is implemented and verified on tiny models on the Mac but has not yet been built on the instance, so no MPACT or compiler-path numbers are reported here. The NumPy reference (`models/tests/reference.py`) reproduces the device arithmetic and is the per-stage golden for the kernels.

3 Correctness

Every kernel matches its NumPy reference on the hardware (`models/tests/fpga_kernels_test.py`); the matrix-engine matvec agrees to 1.2×10^{-7}. A full FunctionGemma decode step traced stage by stage against the reference (`models/tests/trace_compare.py`) agrees to about 10^{-3} relative at layer 0, drifts to a few percent in the middle layers, and ends with the same top-4 logits in the same order. Table 1 compares the generated text for the chat prompt *"What is the capital of France?"* (16 prompt tokens including `<bos>` and the chat template).

Model	Backend	Generated text	Tokens match MLX
FunctionGemma 270M	MLX functiongemma-270m-it-bf16	The capital of France is Paris.	reference
FunctionGemma 270M	FPGA (fused kernels)	The capital of France is Paris.	yes
FunctionGemma 270M	FPGA (per-op kernels)	The capital of France is Paris.	yes
Gemma 3 1B	MLX gemma-3-1b-it-qat-4bit	The capital of France is Paris.	reference
Gemma 3 1B	FPGA (fused kernels)	The capital of France was Paris during the	no
Gemma 3 1B	FPGA (per-op kernels)	The capital of France was Paris during the	no
Gemma 3 1B	FPGA (speculative kernels)	The capital of France was Paris during the	no

Table 1: Chat prompt output, FPGA native kernels versus MLX.

4 Performance

4.1 FPGA (25 MHz image)

TTFT is the wall time of the prefill pass (the prompt is processed in chunks of up to 16 tokens, each chunk costing about one decode step because the weights are streamed once per chunk). Decode tokens per second is measured over the generated tokens after the first. Synthetic prompts ("isl$N$") are exactly N tokens and generation ignores the end-of-sequence token so the output length (OSL) is fixed.

Model	Kernels	Prompt	ISL	OSL	TTFT (s)	s/token	tok/s
FunctionGemma 270M	fused	isl8	8	16	51.5	11.6	0.0860
FunctionGemma 270M	fused	chat	16	8	67.6	11.6	0.0861
FunctionGemma 270M	fused	isl32	32	16	151.8	12.1	0.0830
FunctionGemma 270M	fused	isl64	64	16	303.1	12.4	0.0809
FunctionGemma 270M	fused	isl96	96	16	475.2	12.8	0.0782
FunctionGemma 270M	per-op	isl8	8	16	48.7	28.0	0.0358
FunctionGemma 270M	per-op	chat	16	8	66.8	27.7	0.0361
FunctionGemma 270M	per-op	isl32	32	16	137.6	28.1	0.0356
FunctionGemma 270M	per-op	isl64	64	16	289.7	29.3	0.0341
FunctionGemma 270M	per-op	isl96	96	16	482.9	29.2	0.0343
Gemma 3 1B	fused	isl8	8	8	202.0	41.5	0.0241
Gemma 3 1B	fused	chat	16	8	297.2	41.4	0.0241
Gemma 3 1B	fused	isl32	32	8	610.9	41.9	0.0239
Gemma 3 1B	fused	isl32	32	16	603.9	41.9	0.0238
Gemma 3 1B	fused	isl64	64	8	1235.3	42.5	0.0236
Gemma 3 1B	per-op	chat	16	8	298.3	72.6	0.0138
Gemma 3 1B	speculative	chat	16	8	299.8	66.6	0.0150

Table 2: FPGA results. Entries marked "in progress" are regenerated when the runs finish.

Where the time goes. The bandwidth microbenchmark (`models/tests/membench.py`) measures 0.65–0.77 B/cycle for reads and writes to both DDR and HBM, independent of vector width: about 24 core cycles per 16-byte load, i.e. 16–19 MB/s at 25 MHz. The 1B model streams about 350 MB of int4 weights per token plus 150 MB for the tied embedding at the logits, giving a floor of roughly 30 s per token before any compute; the 270M model streams about 65 MB per token plus the same 150 MB logits matrix, so its decode is dominated by the vocabulary projection. The matvec kernel runs at about 645 cycles per 512 multiply-accumulates in decode (one 16-byte activation load per 16 K values, two weight loads and a scale load per 32-wide group), close to that floor. In the first FunctionGemma run, 637 matvec launches accounted for 120 s of the 235 s total; the scalar GELU kernel for 12 s.

4.2 Fused decode kernel

`models/asm/gemma_decode.S` is a whole single-token decode step in 3.9 KB of assembly: embedding gather, all layers, final norm and the tied-embedding logits with a fused top-8 drain. Int8 activations and their per-group scales live in DTCM, Q4_0 scales are stored as f16 and converted on-chip, softmax and GELU use a vectorized exp, and nothing intermediate is written to HBM. Every routine passes against the NumPy references on the FPGA (`models/tests/fpga_fused_test.py`), and a full fused step returns exactly the top-4 tokens and logit values of the per-operator runtime. For FunctionGemma the step takes 276M cycles (11.1 s), against about 28 s for the per-operator sequence; the remaining time is the weight stream itself. Prefill still uses the per-operator kernels (16 tokens per pass), so TTFT is unchanged; a fused multi-row prefill variant is the next step.

What did not help. (1) Matrix-engine tile loads: a `vtle8` moves one 16-byte slice per instruction, so the bus cost is identical to a vector load (an earlier 16× reading was a benchmark artifact, corrected in `models/tests/tilebench.py`). (2) Speculative decoding with a 270M CPU draft against the 1B target: output identical to greedy, 50% acceptance, 2.3 tokens per verification step, but each extra verified row cost about 26 s on the per-operator path, so the net gain was 72.6 to 66.6 s per token; set aside.

4.3 MLX on Apple Silicon

Model	MLX checkpoint	ISL	OSL	TTFT (s)	tok/s
FunctionGemma 270M	functiongemma-270m-it-bf16	16	8	1.130	53.0
Gemma 3 1B	gemma-3-1b-it-qat-4bit	16	8	0.960	56.9

Table 3: MLX reference runs on the Mac for the same prompt.

4.4 Projection to 1 GHz silicon

The kernels issue roughly 11 instructions per matrix step (64 int8 MACs in decode). If a silicon implementation removed the external-memory bottleneck, instruction issue would bound decode at about 8 tokens/s for Gemma 3 1B and about 60 tokens/s for FunctionGemma 270M at 1 GHz; with the measured F2 bus behaviour scaled by clock alone the numbers would be 40× the FPGA figures. The MPACT simulator path (`tools/estimate_tps.py` on branch `fpga-workflow`) is the intended tool for a tighter estimate and has not been run yet.

5 Hardware findings during bring-up

- **Memory window base.** The core reads wrong data from the first bytes of the HBM window (`0xC0000000`) although host access to the same bytes is correct; the first 64 KiB of each window is now left unused. This was the only functional bug found in the integration: with it fixed, the device matched the reference at every stage.
- **Activation layout matters more than compute.** Gathering sixteen activation rows with strided loads cost 16 bus transactions per matrix step; a k-major layout written by the quantizer (one contiguous load per row) cut the matvec from 50,720 to 7,669 cycles on the test shape, and the decode fast path (one load per 16 K values, rows derived with register slides) brought decode to 645 cycles per 512 MACs.
- **Scalar loops are expensive.** Each scalar access to external memory costs the same 24 cycles; the vocabulary top-k was rewritten as vector chunk maxima plus an exact scan (262,144 logits in 1.8M cycles, 73 ms).
- **Matrix engine.** The int8 `vtmms` path with four K values per instruction works as documented in the repository's VME tests; the signed-by-unsigned mode consumes raw Q4_0 nibbles directly. Tile loads and stores move one 16-byte slice per instruction.

6 Next steps

1. Finish the Gemma 3 1B fused run and single-stream sweeps (in progress) and refresh this report and pull request #10.
2. Fused multi-row prefill (chunking the activation block through DTCM) to cut TTFT the way the fused decode kernel cut decode; move the vocabulary projection to the host CPU for the 270M models (150 MB of the 215 MB streamed per token).
3. Build the coralnpu-compiler path on the instance and compare its F2 backend against the native kernels on the same prompts; run MPACT for the 1 GHz estimate.
4. Reduce weight traffic further: f16 group scales (halves scale reads), fusing the gated GELU into the matvec drain, and batching 16 decode streams to use all tile rows.